Months 7 to 9: NLP and transformers

Quick reference · Senior Data Scientist roadmap · Embeddings, then attention and a transformer built from scratch.

B15 Embeddings and clustering

B15-L1 Sentence embeddings for open-ended answers

One model, recorded and cached. Compare with cosine similarity, and guard against zero vectors.

- **Encode with sentence-transformers**: SentenceTransformer(name).encode(texts, normalize_embeddings=True). Not run in this course's build.
- **Cosine similarity for unit vectors**: The dot product. Otherwise divide by both lengths.
- **Mixing embedding models**: Never. Each model defines its own space.
- **Cache key for a vector**: Text ID, text hash, model name and version.

B15-L2 HDBSCAN, clusters with a noise label

Let density decide the clusters, keep noise as its own answer, and summarise counts, noise share and balance before naming themes.

- **HDBSCAN noise label**: -1: points in sparse regions. Report the share, never treat it as a cluster.
- **HDBSCAN main setting**: min_cluster_size (default 5). min_samples makes it more conservative.
- **HDBSCAN in scikit-learn 1.8**: sklearn.cluster.HDBSCAN. Pass copy=True: the default changes in 1.10.
- **Read a clustering**: Noise share, number and size of clusters, then samples from each.

B15-L3 Validate clusters before you name them

Check separation without noise, stability across reruns, and meaning by reading, before any cluster gets a name.

- **Three checks before naming clusters**: Separation (silhouette), stability (ARI across reruns), meaning (read and name independently).
- **Silhouette and HDBSCAN noise**: Exclude -1 first. silhouette_score treats it as a cluster (0.70 vs 0.555 in this lesson's example).
- **Adjusted Rand index**: 1 for identical groupings, about 0 for chance, can be negative, ignores label names.
- **Examples on a theme slide**: Random verbatims, not hand-picked ones.

B25 Attention and transformers from scratch

B25-L1 Tokens, vocabularies and embeddings

Build the vocabulary on training text with reserved IDs for padding and unknown words, encode to fixed-length integer IDs, and save the vocabulary with the model.

- **Reserved IDs in a vocabulary**: 0 for <pad>, 1 for <unk>. Words start at 2. Build it on training text and save it with the model.
- **What nn.Embedding(vocab_size, dim) does**: Looks up row i for ID i: (N, L) integer IDs become (N, L, dim). Same as a one-hot vector times the table.
- **padding_idx=0**: Row 0 starts at zero and gets no gradient, so padding never learns a meaning.
- **Two embedding errors**: Float IDs raise a dtype error. An ID at or beyond the vocabulary size raises 'index out of range in self'.

B25-L2 Sequence models, recurrence and its limits

A recurrent network carries a hidden state step by step. Set batch_first=True, and remember its two limits: fading long-range signal and no parallelism.

- **The RNN step**: h_t = tanh(x_t @ W_ih.T + h_prev @ W_hh.T + b), with the same weights at every step.
- **nn.LSTM outputs with batch_first=True**: outputs (batch, length, hidden), plus h and c of shape (layers, batch, hidden).
- **batch_first default**: False for RNN and LSTM: (length, batch, features). Wrong layouts often run without error. Set it and assert shapes.
- **Two limits of recurrent models**: Gradients fade or explode over long sequences (0.9 ** 50 = 0.0052), and steps cannot run in parallel.

B25-L3 Scaled dot-product attention

Scores are Q @ K.T / sqrt(d), softmax runs across keys with the row maximum subtracted, and the output is the weighted average of the values.

- **Scaled dot-product attention**: weights = softmax(Q @ K.T / sqrt(d)) across keys; output = weights @ V.
- **Why scale by sqrt(d)**: Dot products grow like sqrt(d): about 2, 8 and 22 at d = 4, 64, 512. Scaling keeps softmax out of saturation.
- **Stable softmax**: Subtract the maximum along the axis with keepdims=True before exp, then divide by the sum along the same axis.
- **Attention in PyTorch 2.15**: torch.nn.functional.scaled_dot_product_attention(q, k, v) on (..., length, d) tensors.

B25-L4 Masks for padding and for the future

Mask padding and the future by setting their scores to minus infinity. Know which convention each PyTorch function uses, and test that later tokens and padding cannot change earlier outputs.

- **Masking in attention**: Set masked scores to minus infinity before softmax, so their weights are exactly 0.
- **Causal mask**: np.tril(np.ones((L, L), dtype=bool)): position i sees 0 to i. F.scaled_dot_product_attention(..., is_causal=True) builds it.
- **PyTorch 2.15 mask conventions**: scaled_dot_product_attention attn_mask: True = take part. MultiheadAttention key_padding_mask: True = ignore.
- **Mask tests**: Changing a later token, or adding padding, must not change earlier outputs or outputs at real positions.

B25-L5 Multi-head attention and position information

Multi-head attention splits d into heads, attends in each and merges them. Attention ignores order, so add learned or sinusoidal positions to the embeddings.

- **Multi-head attention steps**: Project to Q, K, V; split d into h heads of d // h; attend per head; merge and project with Linear(d, d).
- **nn.MultiheadAttention parameters**: 4 * d * d + 4 * d, whatever the number of heads. d must divide by num_heads.
- **Why positions**: Attention ignores order: shuffled inputs give the same outputs, shuffled. Add learned or sinusoidal positions to the embeddings.
- **Sinusoidal positions**: PE[pos, 2i] = sin(pos / 10000 ** (2i / d)), PE[pos, 2i + 1] = cos of the same angle.

B25-L6 The transformer block, residuals, layer norm and feed-forward

A block is attention then feed-forward, each with layer norm and a residual. Set batch_first, norm_first and dim_feedforward yourself, and pool over real tokens only.

- **Pre-norm transformer block**: x = x + attention(norm_1(x)); x = x + feed_forward(norm_2(x)).
- **Layer norm**: Per token: subtract the mean, divide by sqrt(population variance + eps), then a learned scale and shift.
- **TransformerEncoderLayer defaults in PyTorch 2.15**: batch_first=False, norm_first=False, dim_feedforward=2048, dropout=0.1. Set the first three yourself.
- **Pooling for classification**: Mean over real positions only: sum with a 0/1 mask, divide by the count of real tokens.